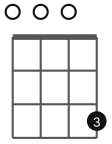
# Danny Boy

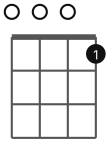
Frederic Weatherly, 1913

Key: **C major** Time: **4/4** Tempo: **66 bpm** Strum: **D-D-D-DU** Starts on: **G7 (V7)**

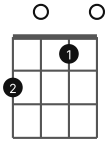
## THE CHORDS IN C, AND HOW THEY FEEL



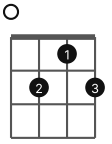
**C**
I
*home*



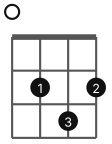
**C7**
I7
*home, leaning on to four*



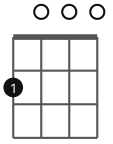
**F**
IV
*away*



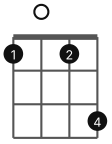
**G7**
V7
*tension (wants to go home)*



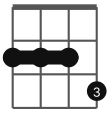
**G**
V
*tension (wants to go home)*



**Am**
vi
*the sad home*



**Fm**
iv
*the sad four, borrowed from the minor key*



**D7**
II7
*the five of five: leads to V*

## THE SONG

**A**
Verse 1
*Oh Danny boy...*

→

**A**
Verse 2
*But when ye...*

- 2 parts in the song, but only 1 different chord pattern to learn.
- One chord pattern for the whole song: learn it once, then it's the words.

## CHORD MAP

## A Verse ×2, new words each time

| | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Oh Danny boy, the pipes, the...* | **G7** V7 | **C** ① I | **C7** I7 | **F** IV | |
| *From glen to glen, and down...* | **Fm** iv | **C** I | **Am** vi | **D7** ② II7 | **G7** V7 |
| *The summer's gone, and all the...* | **G7** V7 | **C** ③ I | **C7** I7 | **F** IV | |
| *It's you, it's you must go...* | **C** I | **Am** vi | **G7** V7 | **F** IV | **C** I |
| *But come ye back when summer's...* | **G** V | **F** IV | **C** ④ I | **F** IV | |
| *Or when the valley's hushed and...* | **G** V | **C** I | **Am** vi | **D7** II7 | **G** V |
| *It's I'll be here in sunshine...* | **C** I | **C7** I7 | **F** IV | **Fm** iv | |
| *Oh Danny boy, oh Danny boy...* | **C** ⑤ I | **Am** vi | **F** IV | **G7** V7 | **C** I |

① **Minor four**: C F Fm C, I IV iv I, in the line “Oh Danny boy, the pipes, the...”. Four, then four turned minor just before home: a bittersweet sigh, loved in ballads and Beatles songs.

② **Five of five (II7–V7–I)**: D7 G7 C, II V I, in the line “From glen to glen, and down...”. A major two leads to five, five leads home: each chord a fifth above the next. Old-time and music-hall songs love it.

③ **Amen (plagal)**: C F C, I IV I, in the line “The summer's gone, and all the...”. One, four, one: the "A-men" sound.

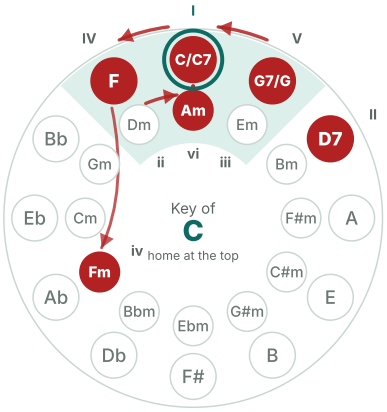
④ **Three-chord trick**: C F G C, I IV V I, in the line “But come ye back when summer's...”. One, four, five, home. Folk, country and rock and roll.

⑤ **50s / doo-wop**: C Am F G7, I vi IV V, in the line “Oh Danny boy, oh Danny boy...”. Home, sad six, four, five. "Stand by Me", "Earth Angel".

## CHANGES TO PRACTISE

1. **F → Fm** (×4): Move your index finger to the G string, 1st fret; move your middle finger to the E string, 1st fret; put your little finger on the A string, 3rd fret.
2. **F → G** (×2): Move your index finger to the C string, 2nd fret; move your middle finger to the A string, 2nd fret; put your ring finger on the E string, 3rd fret.
3. **D7 → G** (×2): Move your index finger to the C string, 2nd fret; move your ring finger to the E string, 3rd fret; put your middle finger on the A string, 2nd fret.
4. **G → F** (×2): Move your index finger to the E string, 1st fret; move your middle finger to the G string, 2nd fret; lift your ring finger.
5. **Am → D7** (×4): Move your index finger across the G C E strings at the 2nd fret (a barre); put your ring finger on the A string, 3rd fret.

## ON THE CIRCLE OF FIFTHS




- Home is C, ringed at the top. Its closest chords sit either side: IV to the left, V to the right, and the minors ii, vi and iii inside.
- G7, C, C7, F, Am, G are in the key's family. From outside it:
- Fm: the sad four (iv), borrowed from C minor.
- D7: the five of G (II7): it leads to G.
- C → Am (I → vi), 8 times: to its relative minor, just inside it on the circle.
- G7 → C (V7 → I), 6 times: five to one: the strongest pull home.
- C7 → F (I7 → IV), 6 times: one step anticlockwise (down a fifth): the way music likes to move.
- F → C (IV → I), 6 times: four to one, the "Amen" sound.

## LEARNING IT

1. Practise the hardest changes above until they're smooth (Learn → Changes...).
2. Play along with the chords, then **from memory**: the chords hidden after the first time each part comes, then as numbers only, then none (Learn → From memory).
3. Play it in another key, thinking in numbers. If you can, you know the song, not just the shapes.
4. Come back to it in a day or two, and again in a week.

## TROUBLE SPOTS

Made with ukemusic on Nov 4, 2026.